By then we had travelled to the Middle East to play a T20 series, an ODI series and two Test matches against Pakistan in the United Arab Emirates (UAE), their home away from home.

Our extraordinary winning streak continued with victories in both T20 internationals and the first one-day international before, on 31 October in Abu Dhabi, we appeared to be cruising to another decisive win when Abdul Razzaq rescued his side with an innings of 109 from 72 balls.

Undeterred, we travelled an hour down the road to Dubai, won the third ODI, narrowly lost the fourth and then won the fifth to secure victory by three matches to two. The team was settled and successful – Amla, Smith, Kallis, De Villiers, Duminy, Ingram, Botha, Peterson, Morkel, Steyn and Tsotsobe – and our minds started to turn towards the challenge, and the opportunity, of the 2011 Cricket World Cup just three months away.

First, we prepared to play two Tests against Pakistan in the UAE. We would certainly have won the first Test in Dubai if we had held our catches, but we were ultimately denied by Younus Khan's resolute century on the fifth day, and the match ended in a draw.

The second Test was played at the Sheikh Zayed Stadium in Abu Dhabi and, having been sent in to bat, we found ourselves in serious trouble at 33 for three on the first morning. Jacques and I remained at the crease, weathered the storm and gradually dragged our team back into the match. Jacques reached his century in the evening, but fell just before stumps.

There was work to be done on the second day, Sunday, 21 November. I woke early and called home to wish my mother a happy birthday, and said I wanted to make it a special day for her.

So we continued to advance our total. Umar Gul was not happy and spent most of the morning chuntering about a decision that had gone against him the previous evening. The Pakistanis were bowling well and